

Google Search Console (GSC) Setup & Indexing Guide

This document explains **what Google Search Console is, why we used it, what exact steps were done, what happens after this, and what future maintainers should or should not do.**

It is written so that *any new coordinator / developer* can understand and continue the process safely.

1. What is Google Search Console?

Google Search Console (GSC) is an official Google tool that allows website owners to: - Tell Google that a website exists - Check whether Google has **indexed** the site - Monitor search performance (clicks, impressions, keywords) - Find indexing or security issues - Submit a **sitemap** so Google can crawl pages faster

Important: GSC does **not** host the website. It only manages how Google sees the website.

2. Why was GSC needed for energysoc.iitd.ac.in?

Before setup: - The website existed, but **Google didn't know about it** - Searching "Energy Society IITD" did not show the website

Goals: - Make the site discoverable on Google - Ensure official IIT Delhi subdomain is indexed correctly - Improve visibility for searches like: - Energy Society IITD - Energy Society IIT Delhi

3. Type of website property used

We used a **URL Prefix property**:

`https://energysoc.iitd.ac.in/`

Why? - DNS access is controlled by IIT Delhi - URL Prefix verification works without DNS access - Best option for college-hosted subdomains

4. Ownership verification (HTML file method)

What was done

- Google provided a verification file:

```
google3f3c2b6f15d30582.html
```

- This file was uploaded to the **actual website root**:

```
/var/www/energysoc/https/html/
```

Verification check

Opening:

```
https://energysoc.iitd.ac.in/google3f3c2b6f15d30582.html
```

Displayed:

```
google-site-verification: google3f3c2b6f15d30582.html
```

This confirmed ownership.

Important rule

! **Do NOT delete this file.** Removing it will break verification.

5. Sitemap creation & submission

What is a sitemap?

A sitemap is an XML file that lists important pages so Google can crawl them efficiently.

File created

Location:

```
/var/www/energysoc/https/html/sitemap.xml
```

Contents:

```
<?xml version="1.0" encoding="UTF-8"?>
<urlset xmlns="http://www.sitemaps.org/schemas/sitemap/0.9">
  <url>
    <loc>https://energysoc.iitd.ac.in/</loc>
    <priority>1.0</priority>
  </url>
  <url>
    <loc>https://energysoc.iitd.ac.in/about</loc>
    <priority>0.8</priority>
  </url>
  <url>
    <loc>https://energysoc.iitd.ac.in/team</loc>
    <priority>0.8</priority>
  </url>
  <url>
    <loc>https://energysoc.iitd.ac.in/events</loc>
    <priority>0.8</priority>
  </url>
</urlset>
```

Permissions:

```
chmod 644 sitemap.xml
```

Submission result

- Status: **Success**
- Discovered pages: **4**

This confirms Google can crawl the site.

6. URL Inspection & Indexing

What is URL Inspection?

It checks whether a specific page: - Is indexed - Can appear in Google search

What was inspected

Only the **homepage**:

`https://energysoc.iitd.ac.in/`

Result

-  URL is on Google
-  Page is indexed
-  Served over HTTPS

Inspecting only the homepage is **sufficient** for a new site because: - Sitemap + internal links allow Google to find other pages automatically

7. Why the site may not appear immediately in search

Indexing $\neq$ Ranking.

Even after indexing: - Google needs time to associate keywords - Ranking depends on relevance, content, and trust signals

Expected timeline: - 1-3 days: pages appear in search - 5-10 days: ranking improves - 1-2 weeks: stable position

Because this is an **official IITD subdomain**, trust is already high.

8. What future maintainers SHOULD do

When adding new pages

1. Add page link to website navigation
2. Update `sitemap.xml`
3. Request indexing **only for important pages**

When updating homepage content

- Update title/description if needed
- Request indexing for homepage

Regular checks (monthly)

- GSC $\rightarrow$ Pages $\rightarrow$ look for errors
 - GSC $\rightarrow$ Performance $\rightarrow$ check impressions
-

9. What future maintainers SHOULD NOT do

✗ Do not delete: - `google3f3c2b6f15d30582.html` - `sitemap.xml`

✗ Do not spam "Request indexing" repeatedly

✗ Do not add `noindex` meta tags accidentally

10. Recommended homepage SEO identity

Homepage should clearly include (visible text):

Energy Society IIT Delhi (IITD) is the official student-run energy club of the Indian Institute of Technology Delhi.

This helps Google rank the site for relevant queries.

11. How to check if everything is working

Check indexing

`site:energysoc.iitd.ac.in`

Check ranking (incognito)

Energy Society IITD
Energy Society IIT Delhi

12. Summary

✓ Ownership verified ✓ Sitemap submitted successfully ✓ Homepage indexed ✓ Google can crawl all pages

The system is now **stable**. Future work is mostly content updates and patience.

This document can be shared with coordinators, web admins, or future developers.